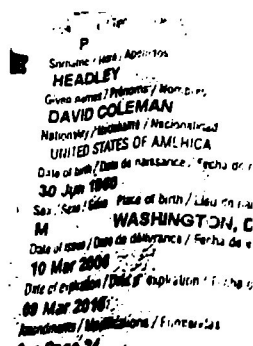




NEW VISA RULES WILL MAKE UNRESTRICTED VISITS TO INDIA HARDER FOR FOREIGNERS

a thorough background check of personnel posted to sensitive ports was not being carried out. It has subsequently been conveyed to the MEA to conduct thorough verification and, if need be, involve the MHA in the task. It also came to light that many Indian consulates were not keeping proper records of the passports and visa stickers sent by the MEA's consular, passports and visas division periodically. The blank documents, including passports and visa stickers, have to be in the custody of an officer not below the rank of an attaché in the mission. "There are reports that Indian passports and visas are up for sale for as little as \$500 to \$3,500 in sensitive diplomatic outposts in the US and UK. All this needs to be curtailed and steps are on to do just that," an MHA official said.

In a related strategy, the home ministry has recommended posting of revenue intelligence officials to missions of sensitive countries. Their task will be to watch terrorist organisa-



(L-R) RANA, HEADLEY AND A COPY OF HIS PASSPORT ISSUED BY THE INDIAN CONSULATE IN CHICAGO

KEEPING UNWANTED GUESTS OUT

MHA has sought details of visas issued by Indian missions in "sensitive" countries.

Intelligence agencies asked to monitor visas issued to Pakistani nationals and those of Pakistani origin.

MHA has asked MEA to introduce accountability for erring mission officials.

MEA also asked for a thorough background check of staff and officials to be posted to sensitive ports.

MHA has recommended posting of revenue intelligence officials to certain countries to monitor terror funding.

Any tourist visiting India cannot reapply for a visa before 60 days.

tions, their funding and money flow to India and monitor financial transactions of underworld operatives like Dawood Ibrahim and ISI agents based in these countries.

Sources said that these inputs were received from the Financial Intelligence Unit as part of pooling in of intelligence by various agencies in

the MHA's Multi Agency Centre. "The effort now is to plug all holes and not depend on another country like the US for intelligence," said a senior home ministry official.

In addition to tightening the functioning of missions, the home ministry feels that the new visa rules for tourists will hopefully prevent more Headleys from coming in. As per the new visa rules, any tourist visiting India cannot apply for another tourist visa before 60 days. However, following complaints of a drastic drop in tourist flow, the home ministry relaxed the norm for those who used India as a hub to visit neighbouring countries. "If the itinerary shows visits to India and other countries as part of the same trip, we have allowed the visa issuing authorities to relax the 60-day period and permit up to three entries into India. But this is subject to stringent checks and verifications," an official said.

In another change, tourists on five- or 10-year visas will have to leave the country every six months and wait for two months before returning. "This has affected thousands of foreigners living in the country or planning long stays. Some countries like the US and UK have protested but our security concerns are paramount," the official added.

India may be losing out on tourism with the new visa rules, but a once bitten twice shy home ministry is bent on ensuring that a repeat of 26/11 doesn't occur. ■